

in building an OS that felt like UNIX but with its internal workings being entirely different.

We need to understand that Linux by itself is only the kernel of an OS. Several critical programs that the user needs are to be written to run on top of the kernel. Torvalds did not write all these programs himself: he used existing, free versions, thus greatly reducing the amount of coding he had to do to make a fully-functional OS. Torvalds worked in depth with the kernel—to such an extent that he often changed the kernel to make it easier to get the existing programs to run on Linux. Generally, the programs are modified to suit the kernel, but Torvalds was a kernel tweaker rather than application writer. Most of the important system software, including the C compiler, was borrowed from GNU project. (More on the GNU project later.)

Linux is what it is today because of the help of developers who worked on it not for money but for the kick of it. They were driven by passion and belief in a cause. Linux is perhaps the single largest collaborative effort in the IT world today. It is not easy to believe that something done out of sheer passion and the fun of programming is now used in several computing devices from PCs in homes to handheld devices to large servers. Torvalds, without even realising it, had written some of the most revolutionary pieces of software in that period.

Linux also carries with it a socio-cultural impact. Torvalds came to the US at the time when Microsoft and Netscape were heavily into the browser wars. People started looking at Torvalds as the man who could take on the battle against Microsoft.

Here onwards, the developments are vast and varied. Just three years later, in 1994, Red Hat Linux and Caldera were released. Red Hat is by far the most popular distribution of Linux. (Red Hat carried with it in-depth documentation and help for all kinds of users, making it a favourite with newbies). Several distributions exist today, some popular, some not so much, and some only for the geek.